HEIGHT ADVANTAGE: England's Chris Haslam becoming star student in U.S. basketball

Haslam Becomes Diamond in The Not-so-rough for Saints

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In its raw form, coal is just a piece of carbon.

When coal is compressed with heat, though, it turns into a diamond.

Chris Haslam has gone through much the same transformation process as a basketball player at St. Andrew's.

An exchange student from England, the 7-foot, 240-pounder is still refining his skills after playing basketball seriously for only a year-and-a-half.

"He told me the other day, 'I guess I was a piece of coal when I came here. Now I guess I'm half a diamond,'" St. Andrew's coach Paul Hill said.

Going into tonight's game against David Emanuel, Haslam is averaging 22.4 points, 17 rebounds and 6.5 blocks a game, while shooting 67 percent from the floor.

He has scored over 30 points six times with a high of 33 (twice), despite being double-and-triple-teamed most of the time.

Perhaps his best all-around game came in a 68-64 loss to Memorial a week ago when he had 22 points, 25 rebounds, 14 blocks, 7 assists and 7 steals.

With those kind of statistics, Haslam has attracted recruiting attention from schools all over the country. Among those who have shown interest are Michigan, Purdue, Arizona, Florida State, Florida, Georgia, Vanderbilt, Virginia, The Citadel, and Georgia Southern.

Hill said one coach called him the other day and told him Haslam was considered the top low-post player in the state.

What has impressed the college scouts the most, Hill said, is Haslam's agility for a big man.

"All of the college people who have seen him say his footwork is excellent," Hill said. "They usually have to teach that. His hands are great and he can run the floor. All they've got to do is toughen him up, put some weight on him and make him stronger."

For his part, Haslam, who played for a club team in England, knows he still has a long way to go.

"I've never been coached before," he said. "This is my first proper stint of coaching. I've relied on my height more than anything else to get me by. I've learned a lot of new moves and also my knowledge of the game has increased since I've been here."

Oddly enough, Haslam said one of the ways he has developed his knowledge is by watching college games on TV.

"You don't get basketball on TV back home," he said. "The only time you can watch is if you have satellite TV and then you get only NBA.

"This is the first college basketball I've seen. I just sit down and watch four games in a row. I study what the big guys do. That's really helped."

One of the things he has had to get used to over here, Haslam said, is playing against smaller players.

"In England, I played in a national league and the guys were 6-7," he said. "They were all 21-22 years old and I was only 17. They were bigger physically and I got beat up a lot.

"I found it hard to adjust to playing against guys 6-2. The biggest guy I've played against this year is 6-5. I went from playing guys 6-7 one-on-one to getting triple-teamed by three little pesky guys."

At times, Haslam admitted that he gets a little frustrated at the constant attention.

"Sometimes you want to put the ball on the floor and take it to the hole, but they're all around you," he said. "I've gotten used to it now. The first couple of games it was difficult. I tried to block everyone's shot and I was picking up fouls."

Before he came to St. Andrew's, Haslam was originally supposed to go to a school in Indiana after former Purdue star Bruce Parkinson saw him in a camp in England.

Haslam said he was going to live with Parkinson in Indiana, but under the rules he would have had to sit out a year before he was eligible to play, therefore he wouldn't have been able to play.

As it turned out, though, a coach in England knew former Armstrong State assistant Dale Mock, whose wife had gone to college with Hill.

Hill said Mock called him and said, 'There's a kid over in England who'd like to come to the United States. Do you all take exchange students?' I said, 'Yes,' and he said, 'I'll contact the kid and if he's interested I'll have him give you a call.' I got a call from his father and everything worked out."

Hill said most of the college scouts have told him they see Haslam as a small forward or big forward.

"Purdue wants him to play the wing and shoot 3's," he said. "He can stand out there and shoot 3's I just don't let him. I stick him inside and pound it into him because there's nobody his size."

Haslam, who scored 980 on his SATs and has a 3.2 grade point average, said he's surprised by how much attention he's gotten from colleges.

"Most of them haven't even see me play," he said. "They've just heard about me."

Haslam said he hasn't thought much about which school he wanted to attend yet.

"I'd like to go the the best school possible basketball-wise," he said. "I think I'll get a good education no matter where I go."

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ing they're going to come down and check us out and see what we've got."

Whether the Tigers will be able to duplicate their success depends largely on the depth of their pitching staff – a huge problem last year.

But newcomers Jason Roundtree from Groves and Jason Radcliffe from Johnson are expected to back up ace Derrick Jenkins and Baylon